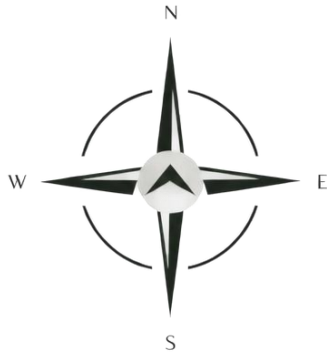




OUTBOUND

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THE VIETNAM GUIDE

A practical guide to planning a better trip

2026 EDITION

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Travel planning, rethought.



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01 — VIETNAM, DONE PROPERLY

Vietnam is one of the best countries in Southeast Asia for a trip that feels varied without needing to cross borders. In a single journey you can move from the energy of Hanoi to limestone mountains, rice terraces, coastal towns, beaches and the intensity of Ho Chi Minh City. The challenge is that Vietnam is long, and the distances between its best-known destinations are easy to underestimate. A route that looks simple on a map can quickly turn into a holiday spent checking into hotels, packing bags and sitting in transit.

The best Vietnam trips are therefore not the ones that fit in the most destinations. They are the ones that create a clear sense of progression. You might start in the north with food and culture, move into mountains or countryside, slow down around Hoi An, and finish in the south. Or you might deliberately focus on just one region and travel deeper. Both can be better trips than trying to see the entire country because a guidebook says you should.

Before choosing individual places, decide what you actually want from Vietnam. If food and culture are the priority, Hanoi and Hoi An deserve more time. If adventure is the priority, Ha Giang can become the centrepiece of the trip. If you want scenery without constantly moving, Ninh Binh is one of the easiest additions. If beaches matter most, Central or Southern Vietnam may deserve a larger share of your itinerary. The route should follow the trip you want, rather than forcing your trip around a list of destinations.

Vietnam also rewards a change of pace. A few busy days in Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City can be followed by somewhere quieter, while a physically demanding experience such as the Ha Giang Loop is better balanced with slower days afterwards. The strongest itineraries deliberately alternate between intensity and recovery rather than treating every day as an opportunity to add another activity.

OUTBOUND RULE: If a destination requires a long journey but doesn't add something genuinely different to your trip, it probably doesn't belong on the route. Vietnam is big enough that every unnecessary transfer has a real cost in time and energy.

The simplest way to think about Vietnam is in three broad regions. **Northern Vietnam** is the strongest choice for mountains, dramatic landscapes, Hanoi and some of the country's most memorable outdoor experiences. **Central Vietnam** combines history, food, beaches and the atmospheric streets of Hoi An. **Southern Vietnam** brings a more modern urban experience through Ho Chi Minh City, alongside the Mekong Delta and southern islands.

You do not need all three.

A week can make sense as a focused northern or central trip. Ten days gives you enough time to combine major regions without constantly moving. Two weeks is where Vietnam starts to feel considerably more relaxed, allowing you to add a major experience such as Ha Giang rather than simply collecting cities. Three weeks gives you the opportunity to travel from north to south at a much more comfortable pace.



The OUTBOUND approach is simple: **choose the experiences first, build the route around them, and only then fill in the gaps.** Vietnam has more than enough places worth visiting. Your job isn't to see all of them. It's to work out which ones make *your* trip better.

OUTBOUND. Fewer places. Better trips.

02 — BEFORE YOU GO

Vietnam is one of those countries where **when you go matters almost as much as where you go.** The country stretches more than 1,600 km from north to south, so there is no single “Vietnamese climate”. Hanoi can be cool and cloudy while Ho Chi Minh City is hot and dry, and Central Vietnam can have a completely different weather pattern again. Rather than looking for one perfect month for the whole country, plan around the regions you actually want to visit.

For a first trip covering multiple regions, **March to April is one of the safest all-round windows.** Northern Vietnam is generally becoming warmer, Central Vietnam is typically in a good period for travelling, and the south remains relatively dry. **October to April** can also work very well for many itineraries, although the north becomes cooler in winter and Central Vietnam can experience significant rain and storms later in the year.

Northern Vietnam has the biggest seasonal variation. Hanoi is generally cooler from roughly November to February, while spring and autumn can offer more comfortable conditions. The mountains around Ha Giang and Sapa can be considerably cooler than Hanoi, particularly at altitude. If a mountain road trip is one of the main reasons you're visiting, don't treat northern Vietnam's weather as an afterthought.

Central Vietnam has its own pattern. Hoi An, Da Nang and Hue can be hot and relatively dry for part of the year but wetter later in the year, with the central coast particularly exposed to heavy rain and storms. If beaches are an important part of your trip, check the conditions for the specific dates you're travelling rather than relying on a general “Vietnam weather” guide.

Southern Vietnam is generally divided into a dry and wet season. Ho Chi Minh City and the Mekong Delta are typically driest from around December to April, while the wet season brings more frequent rainfall from roughly May to November. Rain doesn't necessarily mean a washout: showers can be intense but relatively short, so a southern trip can still work well outside the dry season.

The important point is that **there is no universally perfect time to visit Vietnam.** The right month depends on your route. A traveller spending two weeks between Hanoi, Ninh Binh and Ha Giang has different weather priorities from someone travelling from Hanoi to Hoi An and then finishing on Phu Quoc.

Period	North	Central	South	OUTBOUND view
Jan – Feb	Cool/cold, often dry	Generally good	Warm and relatively dry	Excellent for south; cooler north
Mar – Apr	Comfortable/warming	Generally favourable	Hot and mostly dry	One of the best all-round periods
May – Jun	Hot, wetter	Hot	Hot, wetter	Good if heat doesn't bother you
Jul – Sep	Hot and wet	Mixed	Wet season	Better for flexible travellers
Oct – Nov	Cooler/wetter transition	Wetter, storm risk	Improving/drier	Route needs more careful planning
Dec	Cool in north	Generally favourable	Warm and dry	Strong multi-region option



Weather should influence your route, but it shouldn't completely dictate it. Vietnam's regional differences mean you can often adjust the balance of a trip rather than cancelling the entire idea. If the forecast is poor for one region, having fewer fixed commitments gives you more room to change plans.

Before booking anything, check the **current entry requirements for your passport**. Visa rules, permitted stay periods and application processes can change, and Vietnam has different requirements depending on nationality and how you enter the country. Use the official Vietnamese immigration information rather than relying on an old travel blog or social-media post.

Your passport should also have sufficient validity for entry, and you should make sure your travel insurance covers the activities you actually plan to do. This is particularly relevant if your itinerary includes motorbikes, trekking, diving or other adventure activities. Don't assume that a standard policy automatically covers everything advertised by a tour operator.

Money is relatively straightforward in Vietnam, but it is worth arriving prepared. The **Vietnamese đồng (VND)** is the local currency and cash remains useful for smaller restaurants, markets, taxis, local shops and rural areas. Cards are widely accepted in hotels, larger restaurants and many businesses in tourist areas, but carrying some cash gives you much more flexibility.

One of the most useful things you can prepare before leaving is a rough **route rather than a detailed itinerary**. Know where you expect to start, where you expect to finish and which major experiences you don't want to miss. You don't need every restaurant, café and activity booked before you arrive. Vietnam is much easier to enjoy when there is some space left in the schedule.

If you are travelling during major Vietnamese holidays, check the dates before finalising your route. **Tết**, the Vietnamese Lunar New Year, is particularly important. Transport and accommodation can become more complicated around the holiday period, and many businesses operate different hours or close altogether. The experience can be fascinating, but it requires more planning than a normal week in Vietnam.

OUTBOUND TIP: Don't build your Vietnam itinerary around the cheapest flight or hotel you can find. Build the route first, then look for the best-value way to make that route work. Saving £20 on a hotel isn't worthwhile if it puts you an hour from everything you actually came to see.

Before you book, ask yourself three questions: **Is the weather suitable for my route? Can I legally enter and stay for the duration of my trip? And have I left enough flexibility for Vietnam's distances and transport?** If the answer to all three is yes, you're ready to start building the route.

03 — BUILD YOUR ROUTE

Vietnam rewards good routing more than almost any other part of the planning process. The country is long and relatively narrow, so travelling from north to south is straightforward in theory but can become surprisingly time-consuming in practice. The key is to understand that **distance on the map doesn't tell you how much of your holiday a journey will consume**. A six-hour bus, an airport transfer, a flight and a hotel check-in can turn what looks like a simple move into most of a day.

Start with the experiences you want rather than the cities you have heard of. If the Ha Giang Loop is a priority, build the northern part of your trip around it. If your main interests are food, architecture and beaches, Hanoi, Hoi An and Da Nang may be enough. If you want a classic north-to-south Vietnam experience, Hanoi, a northern excursion, Hoi An and Ho Chi Minh City create a strong backbone without requiring you to stop everywhere in between.



For most first-time travellers, **three or four bases is enough for a 10–14 day trip**. Seven days should be more focused, while two or three weeks gives you the opportunity to add more remote destinations without making the entire trip feel like a transfer schedule.

A useful rule of thumb is:

Trip length	Recommended bases	Best approach
5–7 days	2–3	Focus on one region
8–10 days	3	Combine two regions
11–14 days	3–4	Classic Vietnam route
15–21 days	4–6	Add depth and a major experience
3+ weeks	5–7	North-to-south at a slower pace

These are guidelines rather than rules. A five-day trip could technically include four destinations, but that doesn't mean it should. Every additional base introduces packing, checking out, transport, checking in and getting oriented again. That hidden cost is one of the easiest ways to turn an exciting itinerary into an exhausting one.

The **three-night rule** works particularly well in Vietnam. If a destination is important enough to justify the journey, try to give yourself at least three nights there. There are exceptions for places such as a one-night Ha Long Bay cruise or a short stopover, but repeatedly spending only one or two nights in different cities is usually a sign that the route is trying to do too much.

Geography should then determine the order. A north-to-south route such as **Hanoi → Northern Vietnam → Hoi An/Da Nang → Ho Chi Minh City** generally makes more sense than repeatedly crossing the country. If you're only travelling within one region, keep the route compact rather than adding a distant destination simply because transport happens to be cheap.

Northern Vietnam requires particular thought because several of its major destinations can appear to fit together neatly on a map while requiring very different amounts of time. Hanoi, Ninh Binh, Ha Long Bay, Sapa and Ha Giang are not interchangeable experiences. Ninh Binh is relatively easy to incorporate into a wider route, while Ha Giang is much more of a commitment. Sapa can also involve a substantial journey for an experience that overlaps with some of what travellers seek in Ha Giang. Choose based on what you actually want to experience rather than trying to collect every famous northern destination.

The same principle applies in Central Vietnam. **Hoi An and Da Nang are close enough to treat as one base for many trips**, rather than automatically booking separate accommodation in both. Hue is different and can be worth adding if history and imperial Vietnam are a priority. If beaches aren't important to you, there is little reason to spend several days moving between coastal destinations simply because they're nearby.

Southern Vietnam can also be kept simple. Ho Chi Minh City provides a strong urban contrast to the rest of the country, while the Mekong Delta can work as a day trip or overnight experience depending on how deeply you want to explore it. Phu Quoc is better treated as a deliberate beach extension than something you squeeze into an already busy north-to-south itinerary.

Transport should be considered **before** you commit to your hotels. Vietnam has domestic flights connecting the major cities, an extensive railway running along much of the country and a huge network of buses. Overnight transport can save accommodation costs, but it should not automatically be treated as a free extra day. A journey that leaves you exhausted can reduce the value of the following day, even if you technically haven't lost a night.



There is also a difference between **moving efficiently and moving frequently**. Flying from Hanoi to Da Nang may be much more sensible than spending most of a day on a train if your trip is only ten days long. On the other hand, taking a train can be part of the experience if you have the time and enjoy slower travel. The correct choice depends on what you value, not simply the cheapest ticket.

Before finalising your route, test every destination against five questions: **What does this place add? How long does it take to reach? Could the experience be done from another base? Is it genuinely exciting you? And would removing it make the trip better?** If the answer to the final question is yes, remove it.

OUTBOUND TIP: Your route should make geographical sense even before you look at individual hotels. If you have to keep drawing lines backwards across the country to make the itinerary work, the itinerary probably needs simplifying.

The best Vietnam itinerary isn't necessarily the one that covers the greatest distance. It is the one where each move has a purpose and each destination feels different enough to justify the time it takes to reach it. **Build the route first. Book the details second.**

04 — HANOI

Hanoi is usually the best place to begin a first trip to Vietnam. It is chaotic without being overwhelming, deeply connected to Vietnamese history and culture, and one of the country's best cities for eating. More importantly, it gives you an immediate sense of where you are. The streets are busy, the architecture changes block by block and life happens around you rather than behind the doors of tourist attractions.

Give Hanoi **at least two nights**, with three nights being the better choice for most first-time visitors. Two nights gives you enough time to experience the Old Quarter and some of the city's major sights without rushing. Three nights allows you to slow down, explore different neighbourhoods and have a more relaxed final day before moving on. One night is possible as a stopover, but it is rarely enough to make the city feel worthwhile.

The **Old Quarter** is the obvious starting point. Its narrow streets, small shops, street food and constant movement make simply walking around one of the best experiences in Hanoi. Don't feel that every street needs a destination. Give yourself time to wander, stop for coffee, eat something you don't recognise and see how the city actually works.

The area around **Hoàn Kiếm Lake** is another natural part of a first visit. It is particularly enjoyable early in the morning and around sunset, when the pace changes and the streets around the lake can feel very different from the intensity of the Old Quarter. The lake also gives you an easy geographical reference point when exploring central Hanoi.

For history and culture, the **Temple of Literature**, **Ho Chi Minh Mausoleum complex** and **Imperial Citadel of Thang Long** are the strongest additions for most visitors. You don't need to visit every museum or historic building. Choose a few that genuinely interest you and leave enough time to experience the city between them.

Hanoi's food deserves as much attention as its attractions. This is a city where a meal can be one of the highlights of the day rather than something squeezed between sightseeing. Try **phở**, **bún chả**, **bánh mì**, **egg coffee** and other local dishes while you're here. Street food and small local restaurants are often where the most memorable meals happen, although hygiene standards vary, so use your judgement and favour busy places with good turnover.

One of the easiest mistakes in Hanoi is filling the entire day with attractions. Instead, build your day around **one or two things you definitely want to see**, then leave the rest flexible. Hanoi is at its best when you allow yourself to discover things rather than treating it like a checklist.

For a three-night stay, a good rhythm is to arrive and explore the Old Quarter on the first day, spend the second day combining major sights with plenty of time for food and wandering, and use the third day for whichever side of Hanoi interests you most. That could mean more history, cafés and neighbourhoods, markets, shopping or simply another slow day eating your way around the city.

Where you stay matters. **The Old Quarter** is the best choice if you want maximum convenience and atmosphere. **Hoàn Kiếm** is useful if you want to be central without necessarily being in the busiest streets. **West Lake** offers a more relaxed, modern environment and can work well for longer stays, but it is less convenient if your priority is exploring the historic centre on foot.

Hanoi also works extremely well as the gateway to Northern Vietnam. Ninh Binh can be reached relatively easily from the city, while Ha Long Bay, Sapa and Ha Giang require more deliberate planning. This makes Hanoi an important part of the route rather than simply somewhere to spend your first two nights.

OUTBOUND TIP: Don't book an expensive hotel purely because it has a rooftop pool if you're going to spend most of your time exploring Hanoi. For a short stay, location can be worth considerably more than facilities.

THE HANOI VERDICT

For a first Vietnam trip, **three nights is the OUTBOUND recommendation**. Two works if your overall trip is short, while four or more makes sense if you genuinely enjoy cities, food and culture. Hanoi should feel like the beginning of your Vietnam experience, not an obstacle between the airport and your next destination.

The goal isn't to leave Hanoi having seen everything. It's to leave having understood why it deserves a place on the route.

05 — NORTHERN VIETNAM

Northern Vietnam is where the country becomes much more than cities and beaches. The landscape changes dramatically, with limestone mountains, rice fields, winding roads and small rural communities creating some of the most memorable experiences in the country. The challenge is that **Ha Long Bay, Ninh Binh, Sapa and Ha Giang are often treated as interchangeable stops**. They aren't. Each offers a different experience, and choosing the right one can make a much bigger difference than trying to fit them all in.

NINH BINH

Ninh Binh is arguably the easiest addition to a northern Vietnam itinerary. It combines dramatic limestone scenery with rivers, rice fields, temples and countryside, while remaining relatively straightforward to reach from Hanoi. The area is sometimes described as “Ha Long Bay on land”, but it deserves to be treated as its own experience rather than simply a substitute for the coast.

The standout experience is a **boat trip through the limestone landscape**, particularly around Trang An or Tam Coc. Trang An is the stronger choice if you want the scenery and boat journey to be the main event, while Tam Coc works particularly well when combined with cycling through the surrounding countryside. The landscape changes with the seasons, so don't expect exactly the same views throughout the year.

Two nights is usually enough for Ninh Binh. One night can work if you're travelling efficiently, while three nights makes sense if you want to slow down and explore more of the countryside. Because it fits naturally between Hanoi and other northern destinations, Ninh Binh is one of the few places where adding an extra stop can actually make a route feel better rather than more complicated.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: If you have 7–10 days and want to add one northern experience outside Hanoi, **Ninh Binh is one of the easiest choices to justify**.



HA GIANG

Ha Giang is different. This isn't simply another sightseeing stop — **it's an experience that should influence the entire route around it.** The Ha Giang Loop takes you into some of the most dramatic mountain scenery in Vietnam, with winding roads, steep valleys and remote communities far removed from the major tourist centres.

The traditional way to experience the loop is by motorbike, either riding yourself if you're appropriately experienced and legally permitted to do so, or travelling with an experienced **easy rider**. Don't underestimate the riding conditions. Mountain roads can be challenging, weather can change quickly and the journey involves long periods on a bike. For most travellers without substantial motorbike experience, an experienced rider is the safer and more sensible option.

The classic loop is often completed over around **three to four days**, but the correct length depends on the route and pace. The point isn't to race around the loop ticking off viewpoints. The scenery, villages and journey itself are the attraction, so allowing enough time to stop and appreciate them matters.

Ha Giang is one of the best reasons to extend a Vietnam trip beyond ten days. Trying to squeeze it into a short itinerary can mean sacrificing several other experiences simply to make the logistics work. If you have two weeks or more and adventure is high on your priority list, it becomes much easier to justify.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Make Ha Giang a centrepiece, not a side trip. If you're going, give it enough time to be worth the journey.

HA LONG BAY

Ha Long Bay is one of Vietnam's most recognisable landscapes, with limestone islands rising from the sea. It is spectacular, but its popularity means the experience depends heavily on **how you visit and what you expect.**

A cruise is the obvious option and can turn Ha Long Bay into a convenient overnight experience rather than requiring you to organise every element separately. However, don't book a cruise purely because the itinerary promises a long list of activities. Compare the route, boat, cabin, group size, departure point and what is actually included. The quality of the experience can vary considerably between operators.

An overnight cruise is usually the best way to experience the bay if you have the time. A day trip can work for a shorter itinerary, but spending several hours travelling there and back for a rushed visit reduces some of the appeal. If you're already visiting Ninh Binh, think carefully about whether you need both. They provide very different environments, but both involve dramatic limestone landscapes.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Choose Ha Long Bay because you want the **coastal limestone experience**, not simply because it appears on every Vietnam itinerary.

SAPA

Sapa is famous for mountain scenery, trekking and rice terraces, particularly around the surrounding villages. It can be an excellent choice for travellers interested in hiking and rural northern Vietnam, but it is not automatically necessary.

If you are already planning the Ha Giang Loop, ask yourself whether Sapa adds something sufficiently different to justify the additional journey. For some travellers the answer will be yes, particularly if trekking and rice terraces are a major priority. For others, Ha Giang will provide the mountain experience they were looking for, making Sapa unnecessary.



Sapa also has a more developed tourist infrastructure than many of the remote areas around Ha Giang. That isn't necessarily a negative — it can make the area easier to explore — but it creates a different atmosphere.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Choose Sapa for **trekking and mountain culture**, rather than adding it automatically because it is famous.

WHICH ONE SHOULD YOU CHOOSE?

If you have limited time, **Ninh Binh is the easiest addition**. It offers a major change of scenery without requiring a huge amount of time. If adventure is the priority and you have enough days, **Ha Giang is the standout**. If you want a distinctive coastal landscape and don't mind a cruise, choose **Ha Long Bay**. If trekking is the main attraction, **Sapa** deserves serious consideration.

You can combine several of these if you have enough time, but don't confuse “possible” with “worthwhile”. A two-week itinerary containing Hanoi, Ninh Binh, Ha Long Bay, Sapa and Ha Giang may technically fit on a calendar, but it leaves very little room for the rest of Vietnam.

OUTBOUND RULE: Northern Vietnam works best when you choose **one major experience and build around it**, rather than trying to collect every famous destination in the region.

For a first-time traveller, a strong northern route might be **Hanoi → Ninh Binh → Ha Giang → Hanoi**, or **Hanoi → Ninh Binh → Ha Long Bay → Central Vietnam**. Both create a clear progression without forcing every destination into the same trip.

The north is where Vietnam rewards curiosity. Some of the best moments won't come from the attraction you planned months in advance, but from the road between two places, a small restaurant you find along the way or a viewpoint you didn't know existed. **Leave enough space in the itinerary for those moments to happen.**

06 — CENTRAL VIETNAM

Central Vietnam is where a lot of trips begin to slow down. After the intensity of Hanoi and the landscapes of the north, this part of the country gives you a different combination of **food, history, beaches and slower-paced towns**. For many first-time travellers, the strongest central route is built around **Hoi An and Da Nang**, with Hue added if history is a major priority.

HOI AN

Hoi An is one of the easiest places in Vietnam to fall into a slower rhythm. Its historic centre, lantern-lit streets, riverside setting, cafés, restaurants and surrounding countryside make it very different from Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City.

Give Hoi An **at least two nights**, with three being the OUTBOUND recommendation. Two nights gives you enough time to explore the Ancient Town and experience the atmosphere after dark. Three nights gives you enough room to combine the town with the beach, countryside or a cooking experience without making every day feel scheduled.

The **Ancient Town** is the obvious starting point, but don't spend your entire stay moving between landmarks. Walk the streets during the day, return after dark when the atmosphere changes, and give yourself time to sit down for a coffee or meal. Hoi An works because of the overall experience rather than one individual attraction.

The surrounding area is worth exploring too. **An Bang Beach** provides an easy change of pace if you want some time by the sea, while cycling through the countryside gives you a completely different perspective on the area.



A cooking class is another experience that fits naturally here because food is such an important part of Hoi An's identity.

Hoi An is also famous for tailoring. It can be a fun addition to the trip if you actually want clothes made, but don't treat it as a compulsory tourist experience. If you do decide to order something, allow enough time for fittings and alterations rather than trying to collect a finished suit a few hours before leaving.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Three nights is the sweet spot for most travellers. Hoi An should feel like somewhere you stayed, not somewhere you passed through.

DA NANG

Da Nang is much larger and more modern than Hoi An, with a long coastline, wide beaches, restaurants and a more conventional city feel. For many travellers, it works best as a **base rather than a separate stop**.

The main advantage is convenience. Da Nang has an international airport, making it an easy entry or exit point for Central Vietnam, and it sits close enough to Hoi An that you can visit both without needing to move hotels.

If your priority is beach time, a modern hotel, restaurants and city convenience, staying in Da Nang can make sense. If atmosphere, historic streets and cafés matter more, Hoi An is likely to be the better base.

The **Marble Mountains** are an easy addition from Da Nang, while the **Hai Van Pass** provides one of Central Vietnam's most scenic road journeys. If you aren't an experienced motorbike rider, don't feel that you need to ride it yourself. A reputable driver or organised experience can provide the scenery without turning the day into a riding challenge.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Don't automatically book separate hotels in Da Nang and Hoi An. For many trips, choose one base and explore the other from there.

HUE

Hue offers something different again. As the former imperial capital, it is the strongest choice in Central Vietnam for travellers interested in Vietnamese history and heritage. The **Imperial City** is the obvious highlight, but the wider area contains royal tombs, pagodas and other historical sites.

Hue works particularly well when you want to break up the journey between northern and central Vietnam. It can also be worth adding if you've already decided that history is going to be an important part of the trip.

The trade-off is time. If your trip is only seven to ten days, adding Hue alongside Hanoi, northern Vietnam, Hoi An and Ho Chi Minh City can make the itinerary unnecessarily busy. If you have two weeks or more, it becomes much easier to give Hue the time it deserves.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Add Hue for **history**, not simply because it is geographically convenient.

HOW TO COMBINE CENTRAL VIETNAM

The simplest option is **Hoi An + Da Nang**, treated as one area rather than two separate destinations. This gives you historic streets, food, beaches and easy transport connections without excessive movement.

If history matters more, **Hue + Hoi An** creates a stronger cultural route. You can then decide whether Da Nang needs its own time or simply serves as the transport gateway.



For a beach-focused trip, you may barely need anything beyond Hoi An and Da Nang. For a broader Vietnam itinerary, three nights in the area can be enough to create a genuine change of pace without taking too much time away from the north or south.

OUTBOUND RULE: Central Vietnam should be the part of the trip where you **slow down**, not another opportunity to add three more destinations.

If you're travelling from north to south, Central Vietnam is also a natural reset point. After several days of cities, mountains or long journeys, having a few days where the main decision is whether to explore, eat or go to the beach can make the rest of the itinerary considerably more enjoyable.

The best central Vietnam itinerary isn't the one with the most stops. It's the one that gives you enough time to actually enjoy the places you've travelled this far to reach.

07 — SOUTHERN VIETNAM

Southern Vietnam feels different from the north and centre. The landscape is generally flatter, the pace of Ho Chi Minh City is intense, and the Mekong Delta introduces a completely different side of the country. Further south, the islands offer the option to finish the trip with a few slower days by the sea. The key is deciding whether you actually need all of it.

HO CHI MINH CITY

Ho Chi Minh City is Vietnam at full speed. Motorbikes fill the streets, cafés and restaurants stay busy, and modern buildings sit alongside markets, historic architecture and remnants of the country's past. It is a strong contrast to Hanoi and works particularly well as the final major city on a north-to-south itinerary.

For most travellers, **two or three nights is enough**. Two nights gives you a good introduction to the city, while three allows you to explore without making every day feel rushed. If you're particularly interested in food, nightlife, history or urban travel, you could easily stay longer.

The **War Remnants Museum, Independence Palace, Central Post Office** and **Ben Thanh Market** are among the obvious stops, but don't build the entire visit around attractions. Some of the best parts of the city come from simply walking between neighbourhoods, stopping for coffee and eating wherever looks busy.

Food should be a major part of your time here. Ho Chi Minh City is particularly strong for **bánh mì, cơm tấm, phở, bánh xèo and Vietnamese coffee**, alongside an enormous range of regional and international food. This is a city where planning every meal in advance can actually make the experience worse.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Two nights works for a short trip; **three nights is the better default** if Ho Chi Minh City is your final destination.

THE MEKONG DELTA

The Mekong Delta is a region rather than a single attraction. Rivers, canals, agricultural land and small communities create a very different environment from Vietnam's major cities. The most important decision is whether you want to **visit as a day trip or spend longer exploring**.

For a shorter itinerary, a well-organised day trip from Ho Chi Minh City can give you an introduction without requiring another hotel change. If you have more time and genuinely want to experience the region beyond the standard tourist route, an overnight or multi-day stay can be more rewarding.



The main mistake is expecting the Mekong to be a single spectacular landmark. Its appeal comes from the overall landscape and the contrast with the rest of Vietnam. If you're already struggling to fit the major destinations into a ten-day trip, don't add the Delta simply because you feel you should.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Treat the Mekong Delta as an **optional extension**, not a compulsory box to tick.

PHU QUOC

Phu Quoc is Vietnam's obvious choice when you want to finish with a proper beach break. It has beaches, resorts, restaurants and a more relaxed atmosphere than the mainland cities. That makes it particularly useful at the end of a busy north-to-south itinerary.

The question is whether you need it. If you've already included several beach days around Hoi An, Da Nang or Central Vietnam, travelling further south purely for another beach may not add much. If, however, you want to finish your trip with **three or four genuinely slow days**, Phu Quoc can make sense.

Phu Quoc works best when you treat it as a destination in its own right rather than trying to squeeze sightseeing into every day. Choose accommodation based on the type of beach holiday you want, because different parts of the island offer very different experiences.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Add Phu Quoc when you want a **deliberate beach finish**, not simply because you have spare days.

HOW TO BUILD THE SOUTHERN ROUTE

For a classic first trip, **Ho Chi Minh City + Mekong Delta** is enough to experience Southern Vietnam. If you're travelling for two weeks or more and want to finish with downtime, add Phu Quoc rather than filling those extra days with more cities.

A strong route might therefore look like **Hoi An → Ho Chi Minh City → Mekong Delta**, or **Hoi An → Ho Chi Minh City → Phu Quoc**. If you have enough time, you can combine all three, but only if the beach extension genuinely improves the trip.

One advantage of travelling north to south is that the trip naturally becomes easier to slow down towards the end. You can start with the intensity of Hanoi, take on the mountains or countryside, enjoy Central Vietnam at a slower pace and then decide whether to finish with another major city or several days by the sea.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't add a southern island simply because your itinerary has room for it. Add it because you want the **change of pace** it provides.

The south is also where you should be honest about what you want from the final days of the trip. If you're exhausted after two weeks of moving around Vietnam, another sightseeing-heavy destination probably isn't the answer. Sometimes the best final destination is simply somewhere that gives you permission to do very little.

A good Vietnam itinerary doesn't have to finish with a bigger experience than it started with. Sometimes finishing slowly is exactly what the trip needs.

08 — GETTING AROUND VIETNAM

Vietnam is relatively easy to travel around, but **the best transport option changes depending on the journey**. The biggest mistake is choosing transport based only on price. A cheap ticket isn't necessarily good value if it takes twice as long, arrives at an inconvenient time or leaves you too exhausted to enjoy the following day.



For a first trip, think about transport in three categories: **domestic flights for long distances, trains and buses for shorter or slower journeys, and local transfers for getting between destinations and accommodation.** Once you understand how these fit together, planning Vietnam becomes much simpler.

FLYING

Domestic flights are often the most useful way to cover Vietnam's major north-south distances. If you're travelling from Hanoi to Da Nang, Da Nang to Ho Chi Minh City or another similarly long route, flying can save a substantial amount of time.

This becomes particularly important on a **7–10 day itinerary**. Spending most of a day travelling between regions can represent a significant percentage of your holiday, so paying a little more for a flight can be worthwhile.

Don't compare only the advertised flight time. Allow for getting to the airport, arriving early, security, baggage collection and getting into your destination. Even so, flights are usually the most efficient choice for genuinely long journeys.

OUTBOUND RULE: If a flight saves you most of a day, it can be worth paying more for it. Your holiday time is part of the budget too.

TRAINS

Vietnam's railway runs along much of the country's length and can be a great way to experience the country at a slower pace. Trains are particularly useful for journeys where you want to enjoy the landscape rather than simply get to the destination as quickly as possible.

The famous **Reunification Express** route connects Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City, although travelling the entire length by train isn't necessarily the best use of time on a short holiday. Shorter sections can make much more sense.

Overnight trains can also reduce the need for a hotel night, but don't automatically assume that means you've saved a day. A poor night's sleep can make the following day less enjoyable. If you choose an overnight service, consider paying for a more comfortable berth rather than choosing purely on price.

SLEEPER BUSES

Sleeper buses are one of the defining ways to travel around Vietnam. They're particularly useful for regional journeys and routes where flying would involve unnecessary airport time.

They're usually inexpensive and can be surprisingly convenient, but comfort varies between operators and routes. Road conditions, traffic and journey times can also make schedules less predictable than they appear when booking.

For longer journeys, check exactly what type of sleeper arrangement you're getting. A bus that looks cheap may not provide the same level of comfort as a better service, and arriving exhausted can undermine the money you've saved.

OUTBOUND TIP: For a six-hour journey, the cheapest bus isn't automatically the best option. Look at departure time, arrival time, comfort and your plans at the other end.

LOCAL TRANSPORT



Within cities, taxis and ride-hailing apps are generally the easiest options for visitors. Walking is often the best way to explore central areas, while local buses can be useful if you want to travel more independently.

For shorter transfers between towns, stations, airports and accommodation, private transfers can sometimes be worthwhile when split between several travellers. Ask your accommodation what a reasonable local price is before accepting a private transfer offered at an inflated tourist rate.

Motorbikes are an important part of travelling in Vietnam, but **riding one should not be treated as a casual sightseeing activity**. Traffic can be intense, road conditions vary and licensing and insurance requirements matter. If you don't have appropriate experience and documentation, use another form of transport or book an experienced driver.

HOW TO BOOK TRANSPORT

Don't book every journey months in advance just because you can. For major flights and particularly popular experiences, booking ahead can make sense. For many buses, trains and local transfers, however, you can retain more flexibility by booking closer to the time.

The exception is when a journey is essential to the structure of your itinerary. If missing a particular train or flight would cause you to lose a day or disrupt a connection, that journey deserves more attention than a flexible local bus.

Always check **where the transport actually leaves from and arrives**. Some services use terminals outside the centre, and the apparent journey time may not include the transfer to your hotel. This matters particularly with buses and airports.

BUILD BUFFER INTO THE ROUTE

Vietnam is not a country where every connection needs to be perfectly timed. Give yourself some breathing room, particularly when connecting between different forms of transport.

If you're taking a long bus or train journey before a flight, don't create a connection so tight that a delay could ruin the final part of your trip. For ferries and other weather-sensitive transport, leave additional flexibility where possible.

OUTBOUND RULE: Never build an itinerary where one delayed bus, train or ferry can cause you to miss an expensive flight or lose an entire day.

The best transport plan balances **time, money, comfort and reliability**. Sometimes that means spending more. Sometimes it means taking the slower option because the journey itself is part of the experience.

You don't need to understand every Vietnamese transport option before you arrive. You just need to know **when to fly, when to slow down, and when to leave yourself some room for things not going exactly to plan**.

09 — THE ROUTES

The best way to plan Vietnam is to decide **how much of the country you can realistically experience in the time you have**. These routes are designed around arrival and departure days, not around trying to maximise the number of destinations. A **10-day trip means Day 1 is your arrival day and Day 10 is your departure day**, so the itinerary has nine nights unless your flight timings require otherwise.

7 DAYS — KEEP IT FOCUSED



With only seven days, don't try to travel from north to south. Choose **one region or two closely connected bases** and actually enjoy them.

OPTION A — HANOI + NINH BINH

This is one of the easiest seven-day combinations if you want culture, food and scenery without spending most of the trip travelling. Spend **three nights in Hanoi** and **three nights in Ninh Binh**, leaving Day 7 for departure. This gives you enough time to experience Hanoi properly while still getting into the countryside.

Your Hanoi days can revolve around the Old Quarter, Hoàn Kiếm Lake, food and the city's historic sights. In Ninh Binh, use the time for a boat trip, countryside cycling and the surrounding landscape. This route works particularly well for travellers who want a first taste of Vietnam without constantly changing hotels.

OPTION B — DA NANG + HOI AN

If beaches, food and a slower pace appeal more than mountains, spend **three nights around Da Nang/Hoi An** and use the remaining time exploring the area rather than adding another distant destination. You can combine Hoi An's Ancient Town with beaches, countryside, food experiences and the surrounding coast.

This is also a good option if you want a more relaxed holiday rather than a traditional backpacking-style route.

WHAT NOT TO DO: Hanoi → Ha Giang → Hoi An → Ho Chi Minh City in seven days. It is technically possible, but you're spending too much of the trip getting from one place to another.

10 DAYS — THE OUTBOUND DEFAULT

Ten days is where you can start combining different sides of Vietnam without turning the itinerary into a race. For a first trip, the strongest default is **Hanoi → Ninh Binh → Hoi An/Da Nang → Ho Chi Minh City**, although this can be adapted around your priorities.

Days 1–3 — Hanoi. Arrive and settle into the city on Day 1, explore the Old Quarter and Hoàn Kiếm area on Day 2, then use Day 3 for more food, history and neighbourhoods.

Days 4–5 — Ninh Binh. Travel south from Hanoi and spend two nights surrounded by the limestone landscape and countryside. Use your time for a boat trip and exploring the area rather than trying to fit in every attraction.

Days 6–8 — Hoi An / Central Vietnam. Travel onwards to Central Vietnam and use Hoi An as your base. Explore the Ancient Town, eat well, visit the beach or countryside and leave some time to slow down.

Days 9–10 — Ho Chi Minh City. Fly south and spend your final night in Ho Chi Minh City. Use Day 9 to experience the city and Day 10 as your departure day.

This route works because each section feels different: **Hanoi provides the intensity and culture, Ninh Binh provides scenery and countryside, Hoi An provides a slower coastal experience, and Ho Chi Minh City finishes with another major urban contrast.**

If Ha Giang is your priority, change the route rather than simply adding it. A better ten-day adventure route would be **Hanoi → Ha Giang → Hanoi → Hoi An → Ho Chi Minh City**, accepting that you are deliberately leaving Ninh Binh or another destination out.



If beaches matter more than cities, replace Ho Chi Minh City with additional time in Central Vietnam rather than forcing another major destination into the final two days.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: For ten days, **three or four bases is enough**. The route should feel varied, but every move needs a reason.

14 DAYS — NOW YOU CAN SLOW DOWN

Two weeks gives you enough time to experience Northern, Central and Southern Vietnam while still allowing some breathing room. This is also the point where a major experience such as Ha Giang becomes much easier to justify.

OPTION A — CLASSIC NORTH TO SOUTH

Days 1–3 — Hanoi

Days 4–5 — Ninh Binh

Days 6–8 — Hoi An / Central Vietnam

Days 9–11 — Ho Chi Minh City

Days 12–13 — Optional Mekong Delta or additional time

Day 14 — Departure

This is the balanced option. It gives you a taste of each major region without trying to see everything.

OPTION B — ADVENTURE-FOCUSED

Days 1–2 — Hanoi

Days 3–6 — Ha Giang Loop

Days 7–8 — Hanoi / recovery and onward travel

Days 9–11 — Hoi An

Days 12–13 — Ho Chi Minh City

Day 14 — Departure

This route sacrifices some of the classic stops in favour of one of Vietnam's biggest experiences. If Ha Giang is something you've been specifically excited about, that trade-off is worthwhile.

OPTION C — SLOWER BEACH FINISH

Days 1–3 — Hanoi

Days 4–5 — Ninh Binh



Days 6–8 — Hoi An

Days 9–11 — Ho Chi Minh City

Days 12–13 — Phu Quoc

Day 14 — Departure

This works best if you want the trip to gradually become more relaxed. The island isn't there simply to add another destination — it gives the final part of the holiday a completely different pace.

THE TWO-WEEK RULE: Don't interpret fourteen days as permission to add fourteen destinations. Use the extra time to stay longer, recover between journeys and experience the places you've already chosen properly.

21 DAYS — THE FULL EXPERIENCE

Three weeks is where you can build a genuinely comprehensive Vietnam trip without needing to rush every few days. This is enough time to combine the north, central Vietnam and the south while adding a major northern experience.

A strong route could be **Hanoi → Ninh Binh → Ha Giang → Hoi An → Hue → Ho Chi Minh City → Mekong Delta → Phu Quoc**.

The important difference is that you don't need to give every destination equal weight. Hanoi might deserve three nights, Ha Giang four, Hoi An three, Ho Chi Minh City three and Phu Quoc three, with the remaining time used for Ninh Binh, Hue and travel between regions.

If you're travelling for three weeks, you also have more freedom to use slower transport where it makes sense. You don't have to turn every long journey into a flight simply because it is technically faster.

At this length, Vietnam becomes less about following a perfect itinerary and more about **creating a rhythm**. Busy city → adventure → recovery → food and culture → beach → final few relaxed days. That's what makes a three-week trip feel like a holiday rather than an extended checklist.

THE OUTBOUND ROUTE TEST

Before booking the final version of your itinerary, look at every destination and ask the same question: **Would I rather have this place, or would I rather have the time it takes to get there?**

If the answer is the second, remove it.

Vietnam has enough destinations to keep you travelling for months. You don't need to prove you've seen the whole country. The best route is the smallest number of places that gives you the experience you're actually looking for.

Your itinerary should leave you wanting another week in Vietnam. It shouldn't leave you needing a holiday when you get home.



10 — YOUR FINAL VIETNAM CHECKLIST

A good Vietnam trip is mostly decided before you board the plane. Not because every detail needs to be booked, but because the **route, timing and major decisions** should make sense before you arrive. Once those are right, leave some room for the country to surprise you.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Decide what you actually want from the trip first. Is it food and culture, adventure, beaches, cities, scenery or a combination? Use those priorities to choose your regions rather than starting with a list of famous destinations.

Check the weather for the **specific regions** you're planning to visit. Vietnam does not have one uniform climate, so a month that works brilliantly in the north may not be ideal for a beach-focused trip in Central Vietnam.

Build the route before booking your hotels. Look at the order of your destinations on a map and check how long each journey actually takes. If the route repeatedly sends you backwards across the country, simplify it.

Check the current **visa and entry requirements** for your passport before paying for flights. Requirements can change, so use official Vietnamese government information rather than relying on an old guide or social-media post.

BEFORE YOU FLY

Make sure your passport meets the current entry requirements and that you have any required visa or travel authorisation arranged before departure. Keep copies of important travel documents somewhere you can access them if your phone is lost or damaged.

Arrange travel insurance that covers the activities you're actually planning to do. If you're planning to ride a motorbike, trek, dive or take part in another adventure activity, check the policy rather than assuming you're covered.

Have your first accommodation confirmed and keep the address available offline. It's one less thing to worry about when you arrive tired after a long journey.

Download the maps, booking confirmations and transport information you'll need. Having the important details available without an internet connection can make the first few hours in a new country considerably easier.

BEFORE EACH MOVE

Check the departure point, departure time and arrival point rather than relying only on the headline journey time. Airports and bus stations aren't always close to the centre of town.

Don't create connections that depend on everything running perfectly. If a delayed bus could cause you to miss a flight, the itinerary is too tight.

For long journeys, consider what you'll actually feel like doing when you arrive. Saving money on an uncomfortable overnight journey isn't necessarily a saving if it costs you the following day.

BEFORE BOOKING A HOTEL



Look at **location before facilities**. A beautiful hotel that is far from everything you want to do can make a short stay significantly less convenient.

Check recent reviews, the total price rather than just the headline nightly rate, and what is included. Think about whether the accommodation still works if the weather is poor and you spend more time there than expected.

Most importantly, don't change hotels simply because another area looks interesting on a map. Moving has a cost. If two neighbourhoods offer broadly the same experience, staying in one place for longer will usually make for a better trip.

THE FINAL ROUTE CHECK

Put the entire itinerary on one page and look at it as a whole. You should be able to explain **why every destination is there**.

If you've included Ha Giang, know what you're giving up to make it fit. If you've included Phu Quoc, make sure you actually want several slower beach days. If you've included Hue, know that you're choosing history over additional time elsewhere. Every destination should earn its place.

Then look at the number of travel days. If you're moving almost every day, you're probably trying to do too much.

The final test is simple:

Does this itinerary look exciting, or does it look exhausting?

If it looks exhausting, remove something.

You don't need another 50-page list of attractions. You need a route that makes geographical sense, enough time to experience each place properly, accommodation in the right locations and enough flexibility for things not to go exactly according to plan.

That's the difference between **planning a holiday and building a trip**.

OUTBOUND.

Fewer places. Better trips.